

The first, or transfer, compartment was connected directly with Soyuz 11 – the first spacecraft to successfully board the space station (Soyuz 10 could not enter Salyut due to a mechanical error). Its docking cone had a 2-metre front end diameter. The second and main compartment was about 4 metres in diameter. Televised views showed enough space for eight big chairs (seven at work consoles), several control panels, and 20 portholes (some unobstructed by instruments). The third pressurized compartment contained the control and communications equipment, the power supply, the life support system, and other auxiliary equipment. The fourth, and final, compartment (unpressurized) was about 2 metres in diameter and contained the engine installations and associated control equipment.

Salyut had buffer chemical batteries, reserve supplies of oxygen and water, and regeneration systems. Externally mounted were two double sets of solar cell panels that extended like wings from the smaller compartments at each end, the heat regulation system's radiators, and orientation and control devices.

The Soyuz 11 crew transferred to Salyut on June 7, 1971 and their mission was announced as (1) checking and testing the design, units, onboard systems, and equipment of the orbital piloted station, (2) trying out the methods and autonomous means of the station's orientation and navigation, as well as the systems for controlling the space complex while manoeuvring in orbit, (3) studying geological-geographical objects on the earth's surface, atmospheric formations, and the snow and ice cover of the earth, (4) studying physical characteristics, processes, and phenomena in the atmosphere and outer space in various ranges of the spectrum of electromagnetic radiation, and (5) conducting medico-biological studies to determine the possibilities of performing various jobs by the cosmonauts in the station and study the influence of space flight factors on the human organism.

After flying 362 orbits docked with Salyut, the crew transferred back to Soyuz 11 on June 30, 1971. The mission ended in disaster when the crew capsule depressurized during preparations for re-entry, killing the three-man crew – Vladislav Volkov, Georgi Dobrovolski and Viktor Patsayev – and making them the only humans to die in space.

Salyut 1 was moved to higher orbits in July and August of 1971 to ensure that it would not end through early decay. On October 11, the Salyut engines were fired for the last time to lower its orbit and ensure prompt decay over the Pacific Ocean. After 175 days in space, the first real space station died.

Of course, this was just the demise of the first of the Salyut space stations.